THE STORY OF SUCCESSION

From a father taking revenge on his son by excluding him from a bountiful will to women leveraging modern laws to inherit a grand estate, the Mewar property dispute has all the trappings of a tense family drama

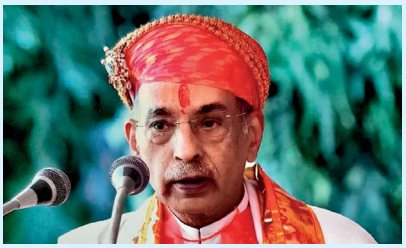


1984

Bhagwat Singh Mewar, the 72nd Maharana of Mewar, dies and leaves behind his estate to younger son, Arvind Singh, departing from the tradition of male primogeniture due to conflicts with his elder son Mahendra Singh

1984–1990s

Mahendra Singh, only left with ceremonial rights, challenges the will and triggers a prolonged legal battle with the other branch of the family





2000s

Arvind Singh gets control over key properties like the City Palace complex, Shiv Niwas Palace, Jagmandir Island Palace and land parcels in Udaipur. Ownership cases continue

2000s–2010s

Arvind Singh consolidates the estate into a hospitality and heritage business through the HRH Group of Hotels, leasing some properties to the Taj Group. Disputes over trusts, access and ceremonies continue

2020

A Rajasthan district court rules that the estate will be divided among Maharana Bhagwat Singh's three children as per the Hindu Undivided Family law, upholding the rights of his daughter Yogeshwari Kumar who has largely remained out of the conflict

2020–2024

Disagreements over the verdict continue, particularly in relation to possession and control. Mahendra Singh dies

the will, while the elder was left only to be the dynasty's ceremonial head. Thousands of Rajputs rallied behind him and crowned him the titular Maharana, but he ended up relinquishing the crown, under what some say was tremendous government pressure. But that didn't mean he was leaving the fray. He contested his father's will, asserted customary rights under primogeniture and property partition under the Hindu United Family (HUF) law, and questioned the legality of the trusts and companies controlled by his younger brother.

What followed was decades of litigation that split the family into rival branches—Arvind Singh, who got possession of nearly all the properties in the meantime and transformed them into popular heritage ventures, and Mahendra Singh, who retained symbolic authority that was evident in the extravagant public mourning of his death in 2024.

In 2020, an Udaipur district court attempted to impose order and directed that certain disputed properties be divided into four parts—one retained in Bhagwat Singh's name, and three allocated to his children: Mahendra Singh, Arvind Singh and their sister Yogeshwari Kumari, upholding a partition suit under the HUF law. A rotational usage formula was prescribed to avoid confrontation over one property, but the peace was short-lived. The Rajasthan High Court stayed the order two years later because Arvind Singh challenged it, wanting to hold onto his outsized share of ancestral properties, and then Mahendra Singh challenged the stay in turn, after which the apex court suggested a doomed mediation.

THE PLOT THICKENS

After Arvind Singh's death last year, his daughters alleged that the will which gives their brother almost absolute control of the royal properties is invalid because their father was frail and alcoholic towards the